

Basic Character Info

Name: Saiph Lovelace

Affinity: Fire

Age: 20

Guild: The Thaumataarch

Gender/Pronouns: Male - He/Him

Place of Birth: Solentharr, Ovrashire

Primary Deity: Solenne

Magical Signature: His magic creates chirping, screeching and whistling sounds of a bird.

Age of Awakening: 7

Personality Traits: Smart, Focused, Observant, Adaptable, Altruistic

Weaknesses: Control-freak, self doubt, fear of letting people down, overworks himself insanely

Physical Description: 5'11, lean, pale skin and faded blue hair

A fun fact about them: He loves sandwiches

He always wears a blue and gold pendant

Voice Claim: Ekko from Arcane

What kind of "Would you love me if I was-" question would they ask?:

Would you love me if I was a stick?



Saiph - Artist: Haban (Found on Pinterest)



Vega - (Traced from a picture on pinterest)



Affinity

Cosmic Affinity, manifests as Fire

Character Lore & Backstory

Name: Saiph Lovelace (*Vega*)

Birth Father: Aldren Zylynore (King of Ovrashire)

Birth Mother: Lyra (Her last name is not known)

Adoptive Father: Sirius Lovelace

Adoptive Mother: Naomi Lovelace

Born as the illegitimate son of the King of Ovrashire, who had an affair (and forced himself upon) with a worker in his employ. When she found out she was pregnant, she came to the King to ask him for help and when the King denied even knowing the woman, she threatened to tell everyone what had happened. The King hence decided to silence her, and put his trusted intelligence network to try and assassinate her. She somehow got away, living in poverty and disguise when her son was born. Even through all this difficulty, she was happy with him. Until they found her. She knew it would happen one day, she couldn't hide forever. She hid her child, and was killed by the assassins, the child never found.

A couple living in the Ember Slums found a child crying on their doorstep in the middle of the night. Blue hair and sharp golden eyes, it was unlike something they had ever seen. Not being able to conceive a child of their own, they decided to adopt the infant. He grew up to be a smart young boy, quick on his feet and quicker with his mind.

[Insert simple fire awakening here]

As he grew up, he was made aware of the atrocities around him. Corruption, lies and death all over the kingdom. He knew he alone could not do something about it, so he took up a different mantle, one that his friend carried before his death. A masked vigilante roaming the rooftops of the kingdom, fighting and uprooting evil wherever he could. He tried to not use his magic, because the signature would lead them right to him. That made things difficult, but he was up for the challenge.

His parents decided that someone with his abilities could do more good in the Guilds and the Academy than in the slums. After a lot of back and forth, it was revealed to him that he was their adopted son, but he had always had his suspicions. Reluctantly, he agreed to join the guilds and put down the mask. For now.

Awakening

“It has been a few years since he has decided to come visit our part of town.” His mom said as Saiph stood on the hill near their home, with his family and a lot of other people from their neighbourhood. He tried to look over the crowd to the only road connecting the Pale Quarter to the Ember Slums. He could only catch glimpses of the decorations made all over the area, garlands and ribbons and fireworks, magical constructs of different colours, signs and boards, all welcoming the King.

The crowd was getting bigger, the hill being a good vantage point. Far away that the guards would not disturb you, and close enough to get a good look at the procession, which they could now hear slowly rumbling towards them. His dad lifted his 7 year old self on his shoulders, so that he could gaze at the parade, with wonder in his gold eyes. He could see the King and his guard throwing out waving to the people gathered near the path, throwing them favours and showering people with gifts from the palace. He had wanted to be down there as well, but his parents said otherwise. It was unsafe, they said. How bad could it be?! It was the King! They had the soldiers there! All of it was so colourful and awesome!

The parade had almost made it to them, as he got off his dad's shoulders and tried to force himself to the front of the crowd, separating from his parents. He could hear them shouting his name, but he still pushed forward. This was his town, he wasn't getting lost! He kicked and shoved all the way to the front, just as the King looked to the small hill they were standing on, waving and smiling. Saiph stared at him, his eyes caught Saiph's, his smile wavered, and then there was light.

Saiph found himself standing alone, on top of the hill. The crowd was gone. The king was gone. He turned around to find his parents, but in their place stood a woman. Well, a silhouette of one. White and glowing, like the light. He could feel the warmth from her, the familiarity. She extended both of her arms towards him, and it did not even occur to him that he had started running towards her, and was wrapped in a hug, the light seeping into him. He looked up at her face, and his own golden eyes stared back at him.

His eyes opened and he heard the shouts. There was smoke all around him, grass singed in a perfect circle. There were wisps of a dying flame, coming from his hand. But he did not feel any pain as he recognised he was the source. He tried to stop it, but failed, as a boy with blonde hair ran up to him, and splashed water on him that seemingly appeared out of nowhere.

He gave him a grin, and then a hand. Saiph took it as he got up, and the people around him looked at the two of them, forgetting the parade, and the King.

(8 years before the incident.)

Burn them all.

Scorch their remains.

Turn them to Ash.

Saiph wakes up with a bucket of water thrown on his face.

“WAKE UP DUMBASS, WE'RE LATE!”

He opens his eyes to see a green pair staring right back. He kicks off his blanket, jumping on his feet and slipping right down to the floor, forgetting that he is completely drenched. “WHAT DO YOU MEAN *WE* ARE LATE?? YOU DON'T EVEN GO TO SCHOOL!”

The boy is standing in one of the few dry patches in the room, made in a perfect circle around him. He pushes his blonde hair away from his eyes and wipes his hands on clothes that are far from fashionable. “I don't *need* to go to that coffin filled with uptight bastards like you.”

“Language, Adrian.” His mother enters as Saiph dries himself. “And no shouting, Saiph. Dad came home late from work.” She takes a look around the room. “...Clean this mess before you leave. Breakfast is on the table. For both of you.” Noticing the hungry green eyes of Adrian as she leaves.

Saiph, now in fresh clothes, heads to the table and picks up a piece of bread. Adrian grins up at him, face stuffed with food. Saiph rolls his eyes at him. “Whuaft? Ift's goof breafd!” He leaves as Adrian rushes to follow. They move across rooftops, both having practised it since they met 5 years ago. Faster than the roads, they said. Adrian suddenly takes a sharp turn away from the school, as Saiph catches up to him. “No school for you today, nerd.” “I can't keep missing it, and you know that.” “Eh- as if they are teaching you something that you don't already know. And I need to show you something!”

They reach the cusp of the forest, when Adrian finally slows down. Both of them fall to the ground, gasping and laughing. “Why are we here?” Adrian steadies his breath and moves inwards into the green sea of trees. He pulls out a small compass from his pocket, and checks something. “C'mon, we're almost there.” He leads Saiph to a tree, larger than the others around it. Saiph could see a construct some hundred feet in the air, and a pulley mechanism in front of him, but there was no way to operate it, except two handprints embedded into the tree. Adrian placed his hand on one of them, and called to the torrent as water collected around his palm. He looks back at Saiph, grinning ear to ear. “What? Need an invitation?” As Saiph puts his hand to the tree, calling to his own element. Orange light glows around them as the bark under his hand starts to smolder. A hatch opens at the top, and a rope drops down.

“How did you build all of this?” Saiph moves around inside the treehouse, marvelling at the rusty but dreamy architecture. Sculpted entirely from the bark of the tree, it had everything that a 12 year old kid would need to survive. Food, water, a bed to sleep, and a punching bag made of wheat and feathers. “This is amazing. Especially that entrance mechanism. There's no way you did this alone.” Saiph traces his hand across a drawing stuck to a wall, of a suit of armor, with a cloak and the mask of a bird. “I cashed in some favors, worked my magic. Well- except the-” And he twirls his hand around, water flowing between his fingers. “It will only open for the two of us. At least it should. I will *break* that woodpecker's nose if it doesn't work, after all I did for him

too?!"

They look at each other for a moment, their eyes meet and they start laughing uncontrollably. "This will be my home. Won't rely on the fosters any longer. My safe haven." "You know you can stay with us right?" "And put my burden on your parents? Hell no. Me stealing their bread every other day is good enough." He gives Saiph a little smile. "It's a few years anyway. Once I'm an adult, I can join the army. Or if I'm lucky, maybe even a guild!" Saiph frowns at the idea. "Whatever, the guilds are a waste of time. And the army is a waste of life. It's not like they care about the likes of us."

"You see- they will care! When I become a high ranking soldier office guy-"
"Official?"

"Yes, that! When I become an Official high ranking soldier office guy they will care!"

Saiph pats his best friend on the back, laughing. "Adrian, the famous Guild Official. Does have a nice ring to it."

(1 year before the incident.)

"They are starving."

"Well- so is everyone else."

"We wouldn't be, if they hadn't burnt the storage!"

Saiph sits at the edge of the lake as Adrian paces in front of him. "I saw them do it, Saiph! And the guards were right there too. Not just the randoms, but some Scaled too. The people are *dying*! They are looting and plundering and killing all across the Ember, while those pompous fools sit in the Pale Quarter eating what we grow!" He finally slumps down next to Saiph.

"I'm sure the guards would do something if they could. You believe in the Scaled, don't you? You have been training to join them! Join them and bring their attention to the people of the Ember."

"It's not that easy and you know it. I was a kid then, I am not a kid now." Adrian lays down, water flowing above in a circle. "What use is our magic if we can't actually help our own people?"

Saiph dips his foot in the cold water of the lake, his voice low. "*Your* magic is useful. Constructive. All I do is destroy." As he chucks a mote of orange light into the lake. Instead of extinguishing, it sinks. Saiph notices it covered with a bubble of oxygen around the flame, it lights up the dark bottom of the lake, devouring the moonlight before the oxygen empties and the fire dies right with it.

"Not when we are together. Never, when we are together." Saiph turns around to see Adrian standing right next to him.

Saiph smiles up at him, and nods. "You know, it *will* be okay. I am sure the Scaled Guard will take some initiative soon. The King can't just ignore all these people in the Ember. He will do *something*, and things will change."

Adrian returns the smile, but his voice lacks conviction. "Yeah. They will surely do something." The words escape his mouth, but he does not believe them. His mind has already wandered to the drawing punctured against the wall of his house.

And for the first time in years of knowing each other, he lies to his best friend's face, and he does not catch it.

(2 hours before the incident.)

He stumbles into his house, a trail of blood following him like his shadow. The sun has set, and it's dark all around him now. He clutches his side, his entire left side in searing pain. He moves to take out the medical supplies from the hidden compartment he installed a few months back. It's empty.

There's a sound directly in front of him, a screech of a bird and the entire room lights up in orange. Saiph stands directly in front of him, fire dancing on his fingertips just like anger in his eyes. "Hello, Vega."

Adrian pulls off his mask, and puts down his cloak. "Saiph- I-"

"You thought you could hide this from me? From *me*?! I had my suspicions, the blood, the bruises. I chalked it up to your usual shenanigans at the fight clubs. But *this*?!"

"You know why I had to do this. You were *wrong*, Saiph! The King has no care in his heart for people like us. We are pests to them. They will not move against the bandits, in fact, I have been gathering evidence that proves that they are in *league* with them! Good for business, they say on the streets."

"So you decided to take the law into your own hands. Become a vigilante and beat them up one by one? You might be powerful, Adrian, but you are not invincible! We might be trained to fight, but guess what?! SO HAVE THEY!" Saiph is a few feet away from him now, the fire burning brighter. "What can you do alone, besides get hurt?" He looks down at the gushing wound on his torso.

"At least I am doing *something*! At least I don't hide behind my books, behind those ideal fantasies!" He sees the hurt clearly on Saiph's face, but he keeps pushing. "Yes, I get hurt. But I hurt them right back. They notice me, Saiph. Some of them even fear this mask!" He throws it at Saiph's feet. "I was naive. I thought I could change the system. I thought I could become a part of the Scaled, make our people proud. I was *wrong*. This world is cruel, and its people are crueler."

There is a sudden sharp ringing, as Adrian pulls out a compass. "I need to go. The cove." Near the lake. "There is something big going down tonight. I am sure of it."

The fire becomes a dim halo around the both of them, as he stares at Adrian. "You are hurt! You can't possibly fight all of them in these conditions! You will die!"

"Maybe. But at least I will have *lived*."

"I won't let you."

"I would like to see you try."

The flames die out, and a few moments pass.

He picks up the mask on the ground, and puts it on. He was always the better fighter. Saiph tries to get up, tries to stop his friend. But this man in front of him is Adrian no longer.

(30 minutes before the incident.)

He could hear the clashes before he could see it. He had tried to follow him, but Vega in his armor was much faster than he was. Saiph lurked around the cove, trying to find a vantage point. He entered slowly, water splashing under his feet. From the dismantled traps and the scattered crates, he could tell that this was the smugglers' hideout. These guys were stealing resources from the Ember and selling them to the highest bidder. *Business*, they called it. Sure, if you dealt in mayhem.

He kept going down the pathway, as the sound of wood and steel resonated across the walls. He finally reached the opening to the cove and peeked inside. It was late at night, with just the light of the full moon and a few lamps here and there. In the middle of it all was Adrian, Vega, fighting 3 on 1. There were still more of them around him, avoiding the use of magic. At the far end of the cove, on a stone platform, Saiph noticed a woman covered fully in stealth gear, a certain insignia on her shoulder that he could not recognise from afar. He tried to keep his panic ebbed, and levelled his breath before trying to get more information.

Most of them were avoiding the use of their magic, considering the amount of explosives lying around. Adrian was smart, not as smart as he was, but still smart enough to know how to work around a battlefield. He moved between the three bodies, crouching and kicking one of them down to the floor before using one of his hands as pivot to launch himself at the other two. The sound of fist against bone echoed as the second smuggler went down. The third tried to sneak up on him, but he kicked down at the staff at his feet as it flew into his hand, and swung it in a deadly arc, shattering bones on impact. He winced, his left side injured, but no one noticed. Except Saiph, and the woman.

The fighting went on, and it looked like he had it under control, until magic got involved. The stone around Adrian rumbled as the woman finally stepped closer to him. He threw his staff to the floor, and closed his eyes as water started to shake and lift into the air. His injuries made pulling at the threads difficult, his body groaning against the stress. The woman cocked her head at him, then rushed at a surprising speed. He barely managed to avoid the blow as the flurry continued. She pushed around the stone at his feet with every punch, throwing him off balance. He fell to the floor, and rolled just as a pillar of stone erupted right where he was a moment ago. As he got up, his eyes fell upon a familiar pair of gold ones hiding in the shadows. And that is when he lost.

Saiph saw the blow coming before Adrian did. As soon as his focus fell apart, the woman used the distraction and rushed closer, kicking him right across the face and throwing him against the wall a few feet down. The mask fell to the floor, revealing his blonde hair, now bloodied. The woman chuckled. "A kid, trying to be a hero. We could have used a fighter like you. Oh well."

Saiph rushes out of the shadow, too late to save him. Just in time to witness what was about to happen. The woman pulled at the strings of the world, as the dirt around them looked like it had started to flow. A shard of stone jutted out of the ground right beside her, as she picked it up.

"NO!"

He almost reached her. That's what he would tell himself for years to come. That he did everything he could. But it made no difference, as the woman stabbed the shard straight into Adrian's heart.

(A minute before the incident.)

He stares at his friend's body, mind numb.

Burn them all.

He lifts his hand, orange flames rushing across his palm.

Scorch their remains.

They turn a dark shade of red, as if he had called the fires from the depths of hell itself.

Turn them to Ash.

The blood red burns away as the cove lights up in gleaming sapphire.

Woe be upon them.

And the world goes white.

(A month after the incident.)

He looks down at the city. Few have access to constant light in this sector. Rest rely on the burning oil lamps. The wisps of smoke are visible even from the height of the clocktower he now stands on.

They've forgotten already. Gone back to their routine of oppression and starvation. He crumples a piece of paper under his foot, an article from a newspaper. They say the bones were burnt beyond recognition, they say the entire area had caved in. The explosives, they say. And he believes them. What other explanation could there be?

That night is a blank in his memory. He remembers waking up back at the treehouse. He remembers the death, the flames. He remembers going back to the scene of the crime, and panic that had risen in his throat. There were no bodies to bury. He remembers the patch of cloth with the insignia on it, the only thing that survived the blast. It now stuck to the wall of his friend's house, right next to a picture of them together. Innocent and naive, the kids they were.

A shriek brings him back to the present. He lets the crumpled paper fall to the ground, as he hides his blue hair under a hood. He twirls a staff with his left hand as he puts his mask on with the right.

And he jumps.

Saiph Backstory

(8 years before the incident.)

Burn them all.

Scorch their remains.

Turn them to Ash.

Saiph wakes up with a bucket of water thrown on his face.

“WAKE UP DUMBASS, WE’RE LATE!”

He opens his eyes to see a green pair staring right back. He kicks off his blanket, jumping on his feet and slipping right down to the floor, forgetting that he is completely drenched. “WHAT DO YOU MEAN *WE* ARE LATE?? YOU DON’T EVEN GO TO SCHOOL!”

The boy is standing in one of the few dry patches in the room, made in a perfect circle around him. He pushes his blonde hair away from his eyes and wipes his hands on clothes that are far from fashionable. “I don’t *need* to go to that coffin filled with uptight bastards like you.”

“Language, Adrian.” His mother enters as Saiph dries himself. “And no shouting, Saiph. Dad came home late from work.” She takes a look around the room. “...Clean this mess before you leave. Breakfast is on the table. For both of you.” Noticing the hungry green eyes of Adrian as she leaves.

Saiph, now in fresh clothes, heads to the table and picks up a piece of bread. Adrian grins up at him, face stuffed with food. Saiph rolls his eyes at him. “Whuaft? Ift’s goof breaofd!” He leaves as Adrian rushes to follow. They move across rooftops, both having practised it since they met 5 years ago. Faster than the roads, they said. Adrian suddenly takes a sharp turn away from the school, as Saiph catches up to him. “No school for you today, nerd.” “I can’t keep missing it, and you know that.” “Eh- as if they are teaching you something that you don’t already know. And I need to show you something!”

They reach the cusp of the forest, when Adrian finally slows down. Both of them fall to the ground, gasping and laughing. “Why are we here?” Adrian steadies his breath and moves inwards into the green sea of trees. He pulls out a small compass from his pocket, and checks something. “C’mon, we’re almost there.” He leads Saiph to a tree, larger than the others around it. Saiph could see a construct some hundred feet in the air, and a pulley mechanism in front of him, but there was no way to operate it, except two handprints embedded into the tree. Adrian placed his hand on one of them, and called to the torrent as water collected around his palm. He looks back at Saiph, grinning ear to ear. “What? Need an invitation?” As Saiph puts his hand to the tree, calling to his own element. Orange light glows around them as the bark under his hand starts to smolder. A hatch opens at the top, and a rope drops down.

“How did you build all of this?” Saiph moves around inside the treehouse, marvelling at the rusty but dreamy architecture. Sculpted entirely from the bark of the tree, it had everything that a 12 year old kid would need to survive. Food, water, a bed to sleep, and a punching bag made of wheat and feathers. “This is amazing. Especially that entrance mechanism. There’s no way you did this alone.” Saiph traces his hand across a drawing stuck to a wall, of a suit of armor, with a cloak and the mask of a bird. “I cashed in some favors, worked my magic. Well- except the-” And he twirls his hand around, water flowing between his fingers. “It will only open for the two of us. At least it should. I will *break* that woodpecker’s nose if it doesn’t work, after all I did for him too?!”

They look at each other for a moment, their eyes meet and they start laughing uncontrollably. "This will be my home. Won't rely on the fosters any longer. My safe haven." "You know you can stay with us right?" "And put my burden on your parents? Hell no. Me stealing their bread every other day is good enough." He gives Saiph a little smile. "It's a few years anyway. Once I'm an adult, I can join the army. Or if I'm lucky, maybe even a guild!" Saiph frowns at the idea. "Whatever, the guilds are a waste of time. And the army is a waste of life. It's not like they care about the likes of us."

"You see- they will care! When I become a high ranking soldier office guy-"

"Official?"

"Yes, that! When I become an Official high ranking soldier office guy they will care!"

Saiph pats his best friend on the back, laughing. "Adrian, the famous Guild Official. Does have a nice ring to it."

(1 year before the incident.)

"They are starving."

"Well- so is everyone else."

"We wouldn't be, if they hadn't burnt the storage!"

Saiph sits at the edge of the lake as Adrian paces in front of him. "I saw them do it, Saiph! And the guards were right there too. Not just the randoms, but some Scaled too. The people are *dying*! They are looting and plundering and killing all across the Ember, while those pompous fools sit in the Pale Quarter eating what we grow!" He finally slumps down next to Saiph.

"I'm sure the guards would do something if they could. You believe in the Scaled, don't you? You have been training to join them! Join them and bring their attention to the people of the Ember."

"It's not that easy and you know it. I was a kid then, I am not a kid now." Adrian lays down, water flowing above in a circle. "What use is our magic if we can't actually help our own people?"

Saiph dips his foot in the cold water of the lake, his voice low. "*Your* magic is useful. Constructive. All I do is destroy." As he chucks a mote of orange light into the lake. Instead of extinguishing, it sinks. Saiph notices it covered with a bubble of oxygen around the flame, it lights up the dark bottom of the lake, devouring the moonlight before the oxygen empties and the fire dies right with it.

"Not when we are together. Never, when we are together." Saiph turns around to see Adrian standing right next to him.

Saiph smiles up at him, and nods. "You know, it *will* be okay. I am sure the Scaled Guard will take some initiative soon. The King can't just ignore all these people in the Ember. He will do *something*, and things will change."

Adrian returns the smile, but his voice lacks conviction. "Yeah. They will surely do something." The words escape his mouth, but he does not believe them. His mind has already wandered to the drawing punctured against the wall of his house.

And for the first time in years of knowing each other, he lies to his best friend's face, and he

does not catch it.

(2 hours before the incident.)

He stumbles into his house, a trail of blood following him like his shadow. The sun has set, and it's dark all around him now. He clutches his side, his entire left side in searing pain. He moves to take out the medical supplies from the hidden compartment he installed a few months back. It's empty.

There's a sound directly in front of him, a screech of a bird and the entire room lights up in orange. Saiph stands directly in front of him, fire dancing on his fingertips just like anger in his eyes. "Hello, Vega."

Adrian pulls off his mask, and puts down his cloak. "Saiph- I-"

"You thought you could hide this from me? From *me*?! I had my suspicions, the blood, the bruises. I chalked it up to your usual shenanigans at the fight clubs. But *this*?!"

"You know why I had to do this. You were *wrong*, Saiph! The King has no care in his heart for people like us. We are pests to them. They will not move against the bandits, in fact, I have been gathering evidence that proves that they are in *league* with them! Good for business, they say on the streets."

"So you decided to take the law into your own hands. Become a vigilante and beat them up one by one? You might be powerful, Adrian, but you are not invincible! We might be trained to fight, but guess what?! SO HAVE THEY!" Saiph is a few feet away from him now, the fire burning brighter. "What can you do alone, besides get hurt?" He looks down at the gushing wound on his torso.

"At least I am doing *something*! At least I don't hide behind my books, behind those ideal fantasies!" He sees the hurt clearly on Saiph's face, but he keeps pushing. "Yes, I get hurt. But I hurt them right back. They notice me, Saiph. Some of them even fear this mask!" He throws it at Saiph's feet. "I was naive. I thought I could change the system. I thought I could become a part of the Scaled, make our people proud. I was *wrong*. This world is cruel, and its people are crueler."

There is a sudden sharp ringing, as Adrian pulls out a compass. "I need to go. The cove." Near the lake. "There is something big going down tonight. I am sure of it."

The fire becomes a dim halo around the both of them, as he stares at Adrian. "You are hurt! You can't possibly fight all of them in these conditions! You will die!"

"Maybe. But at least I will have *lived*."

"I won't let you."

"I would like to see you try."

The flames die out, and a few moments pass.

He picks up the mask on the ground, and puts it on. He was always the better fighter. Saiph tries to get up, tries to stop his friend. But this man in front of him is Adrian no longer.

(30 minutes before the incident.)

He could hear the clashes before he could see it. He had tried to follow him, but Vega in his armor was much faster than he was. Saiph lurked around the cove, trying to find a vantage point. He entered slowly, water splashing under his feet. From the dismantled traps and the scattered crates, he could tell that this was the smugglers' hideout. These guys were stealing resources from the Ember and selling them to the highest bidder. *Business*, they called it. Sure, if you dealt in mayhem.

He kept going down the pathway, as the sound of wood and steel resonated across the walls. He finally reached the opening to the cove and peeked inside. It was late at night, with just the light of the full moon and a few lamps here and there. In the middle of it all was Adrian, Vega, fighting 3 on 1. There were still more of them around him, avoiding the use of magic. At the far end of the cove, on a stone platform, Saiph noticed a woman covered fully in stealth gear, a certain insignia on her shoulder that he could not recognise from afar. He tried to keep his panic ebbed, and levelled his breath before trying to get more information.

Most of them were avoiding the use of their magic, considering the amount of explosives lying around. Adrian was smart, not as smart as he was, but still smart enough to know how to work around a battlefield. He moved between the three bodies, crouching and kicking one of them down to the floor before using one of his hands as pivot to launch himself at the other two. The sound of fist against bone echoed as the second smuggler went down. The third tried to sneak up on him, but he kicked down at the staff at his feet as it flew into his hand, and swung it in a deadly arc, shattering bones on impact. He winced, his left side injured, but no one noticed. Except Saiph, and the woman.

The fighting went on, and it looked like he had it under control, until magic got involved. The stone around Adrian rumbled as the woman finally stepped closer to him. He threw his staff to the floor, and closed his eyes as water started to shake and lift into the air. His injuries made pulling at the threads difficult, his body groaning against the stress. The woman cocked her head at him, then rushed at a surprising speed. He barely managed to avoid the blow as the flurry continued. She pushed around the stone at his feet with every punch, throwing him off balance. He fell to the floor, and rolled just as a pillar of stone erupted right where he was a moment ago. As he got up, his eyes fell upon a familiar pair of gold ones hiding in the shadows. And that is when he lost.

Saiph saw the blow coming before Adrian did. As soon as his focus fell apart, the woman used the distraction and rushed closer, kicking him right across the face and throwing him against the wall a few feet down. The mask fell to the floor, revealing his blonde hair, now bloodied. The woman chuckled. "A kid, trying to be a hero. We could have used a fighter like you. Oh well."

Saiph rushes out of the shadow, too late to save him. Just in time to witness what was about to happen. The woman pulled at the strings of the world, as the dirt around them looked like it had started to flow. A shard of stone jutted out of the ground right beside her, as she picked it up.

"NO!"

He almost reached her. That's what he would tell himself for years to come. That he did everything he could. But it made no difference, as the woman stabbed the shard straight into Adrian's heart.

(A minute before the incident.)

He stares at his friend's body, mind numb.

Burn them all.

He lifts his hand, orange flames rushing across his palm.

Scorch their remains.

They turn a dark shade of red, as if he had called the fires from the depths of hell itself.

Turn them to Ash.

The blood red burns away as the cove lights up in gleaming sapphire.

Woe be upon them.

And the world goes white.

(A month after the incident.)

He looks down at the city. Few have access to constant light in this sector. Rest rely on the burning oil lamps. The wisps of smoke are visible even from the height of the clocktower he now stands on.

They've forgotten already. Gone back to their routine of oppression and starvation. He crumples a piece of paper under his fist, an article from a newspaper. They say the bones were burnt beyond recognition, they say the entire area had caved in. The explosives, they say. And he believes them. What other explanation could there be?

That night is a blank in his memory. He remembers waking up back at the treehouse. He remembers the death, the flames. He remembers going back to the scene of the crime, and panic that had risen in his throat. There were no bodies to bury. He remembers the patch of cloth with the insignia on it, the only thing that survived the blast. It now stuck to the wall of his friend's house, right next to a picture of them together. Innocent and naive, the kids they were.

A shriek brings him back to the present. He lets the crumpled paper fall to the ground, as he hides his blue hair under a hood. He twirls a staff with his left hand as he puts his mask on with the right.

And he jumps.